



Photo by E. Joseph Downing, Chronicle Staff

Respect Child's Privacy Until Trouble Looms

It's essential to grow for a child to develop areas of privacy in what he thinks, says and does. Yet his assertion of the right to privacy often is difficult for parents to handle.

Some parents permit their children no privacy at all.

Others, and I believe their number is growing, allow far too much. Under the well-intentioned guise of "respecting

their privacy," they never pry, never question, never intrude even when trouble is brewing.

Obviously, there's a happy middle ground somewhere between these two extremes.

The withholding of certain thoughts, feelings and activities from parents and others is an early need in all children, and as the child grows, so does

the need. It reflects his increasing autonomy and individuality, his development of a sense of experiment that is a major step on the road to maturity.

It should be respected. The privacy of his diary, mail, telephone calls and quiet moments behind closed doors should be honored. So should his right to private thoughts and feelings.

But that doesn't mean parents must never probe, intrude or ask questions such as: "Where are you going?" "Who are you going out with?" "What have you been doing?"

Nor, like a woman I know, should they refrain from breaking into a child's privacy when there are grounds for suspecting real trouble.

While struggling her 14-year-old daughter's bedroom the woman inadvertently came across a short note that made clear the child was experimenting with drugs. Although torn over what to do, she decided she had no business "violating" the girl's privacy by reading the note, and did nothing about it.

The child became deeply involved in drugs a few months later and had to be hospitalized, under special psychiatric care. The result, perhaps could have been avoided if the mother had recognized that privacy was not the issue—safety and survival were far more important.

This question of when to respect a child's privacy and when to intrude upon it is rarely as clear cut. There are many incidents in every home that fall into a gray area in which it is hard even for the best parents to know whether or not to intrude.

My own guideline for negotiating through the fuzzy gray areas is to ask myself, honestly, whether I have real grounds for believing the child's health, safety or emotional well-being are at risk if I don't intervene. When a parent is sincerely convinced that the answer to the question is Yes, then prying probably is justified.

Generally, however, I suggest respect for a youngster's basic need to keep some things to himself. It is his right as a person to handle parts of his life in total privacy. Developing this ability to go it alone is essential to his growth.

Psychiatrist's Notebook

By Saul Kappel



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Coded Menu Stumps Engineers

Confusion Served As the Main Course

Betty Ewing



HASH-SLINGING SLANG is discouraged so as not to confuse the cook, according to veteran Houston restaurateur Allen Gibson.

"We try to standardize," said the former Houston Restaurant Association president whose executive orders are turned in at Houston's seven One's A Month. He's vice-president and general manager of Brooks Shop Systems.

There still are a few standard hangers-on like BLAT (Blancet and Tomato) from the days when two slipwicks on a raft meant a pair of scrambled eggs on toast.

"Sometimes today oldtimers will come in and order a Real Estate," he said. "That's—brace yourself—a Swiss cheese and jelly."

And for reasons Allen can't recall a peanut butter and jelly is known as a PG, not a PBJ.

Recently a group of engineers, famous for their fancy figuring bugged down in frustration trying to select from a menu at the showplace home of Frank and Rita Meyko. They were the ones confused-out the cooks. The cooks were their wives who purposely created the confusion.

Who could fashion that a Dandelion Diet would turn out to be a stuffed (see hee) tomato. And Pump Money? Confound, dummy.

Certain members of the San Jacinto chapter of the Texas Society of Professional Engineers blabbed to discover they were stuck with a Lower Chest Complaint (breast of beef) and no Snake's Tongue. That's a fork, ma'am, according to the Auxiliary's coded menu. Chairman Meriel (Mrs. Frank) Silcox and her assistant, Dorothy Mrs. Paul Reeves, were the authors.

A slide rule was no help.

TSPE president Jim Beach chose a bountiful plate for First Lady Evelyn but his own was a mile sparse. But how could Jim know that Don Juan's Troubles and a Cute Chick (sounds like a delightful if slightly Freudian pair) were, respectively, a Spanish olive and pickle and a cookie.

Lip Service turned out to be a napkin (diapers were permitted to mark six out of 10 items) and Billy was butter.

The item that stumped the experts at the Auxiliary's Succulent Super Supper was Nightshade Gathering. Only a botanist would know that nightshade can be a type of potato and gathering puts it in the salad category.

The Meykos (Frank is a past president of TSPE) and Auxiliary president Charlene Jochen and husband Curtis greeted the guests. And those included Joe Jeanen, president of the Houston Engineering & Scientific Society, and wife Billie, Bobbie and Bill Avery, Jane and Don Douglas, Les and Harold Mike and Alice and Barbara Jones.

SPEAKING of matters scientific and social, the Houston Museum of Natural Science is planning a splendid debut for a dinosaur on Nov. 23. Took years of reclamation, too, for Diplodocus, a 70-footer that died 120 million years ago and was discovered in 1862 on the Red Fork of Powder River in Johnson County, Wyoming. The din would be pleased at the magnificent portrait due by Houston artist Herb Meurs for the invitation.

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